

**What else to watch:** *La Belle et la Bête* (1946, pp.84–85) ■ *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946, pp.88–93) ■ *Andrei Rublev* (1966) ■ *Alice in the Cities* (1974) ■ *The American Friend* (1977) ■ *The Marriage of Maria Braun* (1979)

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Film is a very, very powerful medium. It can either confirm the idea that things are wonderful the way they are, or it can reinforce the conception that things can be changed.

**Wim Wenders**

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### Watching from on high

At the beginning of the movie two angels, Damiel (Bruno Ganz) and Cassiel (Otto Sander), gaze down at the city of Berlin from on high, gliding through the air or poised atop the city's great monuments. They are there to listen and observe, as they have done since long before the city was built. Their role is to give people hope, or the intuition that they are not alone. However, they are unable to intervene directly—and they are unable to experience anything physically themselves.

The movie unfolds at a measured pace. It is patient, like the angels themselves as they listen in on human thoughts, fears,



**The movie poster** shows the angel Damiel perched high above Berlin at the top of the Victory Statue. The movie's sweeping shots give an angel's-eye view of the city.

and dreams, almost as if they were listening to snatches from different radio stations while turning the dial—parents worried about their son, the memories of a Holocaust victim. The angels may sometimes be sensed, but only children can actually see them.

### Why am I here?

At the start of the movie is a poem, written by Handke, which explains why. “When the child was a child, it didn’t know it was a child. Everything was full of life, and all life was one.” Later in the movie, the poem continues, “When the child was a child, it was the time of the following questions: Why am I me and why not you? Why am I here and why not there?”

The angels, who know the answers to these questions, are somehow bereft. They might know and see everything as they gaze »

“To draw **all the demons** of the earth from passers-by and **to chase them out** into the world. **To be a savage.**”

**Marion / Wings of Desire**